French partitive articles

When referring to a noun whose quantity or amount is not specified, French speakers use the partitive article, which conveys essentially the same meaning as **some** or **any** in English. For example, rather than saying the equivalent of I bought cheese, French speakers always say, I bought some cheese. This rule cannot be ignored.

The partitive article refers to an unspecified quantity of food, liquid, or some other uncountable noun. It is also used with abstract nouns. English has no equivalent article – the partitive is usually translated by the adjectives "some" or "any," or may be left out entirely.

Examples…

Achète des épinards. Buy some spinach.

J'ai mangé du pain hier. I ate bread yesterday.

French partitive articles

	Masculine	Feminine
Singular	***du, de l'***	***de la, de l'***
Plural	***des***	***des***

+ There are three singular articles:

1. Masculine: *du*
2. Feminine: *de la*
3. Contracted (masculine or feminine in front of vowel or mute h): *de l'*

+ There is only one plural partitive article: *des*.

Using partitive articles

The partitive article is needed when talking about an unknown or unspecified quantity of something uncountable.

Par exemple…

Je veux de l'eau. I want some water.

J'ai acheté des pâtes. I bought some pasta.

Water and pasta are both uncountable – you can't ask "how many" water or pasta, only "how much." That's how you know to use the partitive rather than the indefinite article.

The partitive is used with abstract nouns after verbs like *avoir* and *falloir*.

Par exemple…

Tu as de la chance. You're lucky.

Il faut du courage. You need courage.

The partitive is also used with *faire* and *jouer* plus musical instruments, and with *faire* for sports and other activities in the sense of practicing.

Par exemple…

Je fais / joue du violon. I play the violin.

Il fait du droit. He practices law.

Elle joue de la guitare She plays the guitare

SOME GENERAL EXAMPLES

MASCULINE	FEMININE	PLURAL	M/F WITH A VOWEL
Du pain-some bread Du beurre-some butter Du jus de fruit-some fruit juice Du bois-some wood Du chocolat-some chocolate Du gateau- some cake Du vent- some wind Du riz-some rice Du poisson-some fish Du lait-somee milk Du poulet-some chicken	De la tarte-some pie De la poussiere-some dust De la margarine De la glace- some ice cream De la confiture-some jam De la creme-some cream De la salade-some salad	Des frites-some crisps/chips Des haricots-some beans Des arachides- some peanuts Des pates-some pasta	De l'argent De l'eau De l'ail De l'huile De l'essence

Note that this list is not exhaustive therefore you can look for more and add.

FREDA M. NEWMAN